PROPOSAL

Group Customer Complaint Platform

Group	BEST
Factories	Factory A, Factory B, Factory C, Factory D, Factory E
Prepared by	YL Pang
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Status	Draft for review by the project PIC

1. Summary

BEST operates five factories (Factory A to Factory E), each currently managing customer complaints independently using Excel-based logs and reports. This results in inconsistent processes, limited visibility of complaint status, and duplicated administrative effort.

To address these challenges, IT proposes implementing a centralized Customer Complaint Management Platform for all factories. The platform will standardize the complaint handling process, provide real-time visibility of complaint status, improve tracking and accountability, and replace the existing Excel Customer Complaint Log and Customer Complaint Report with a single digital repository.

Under the proposed process, complaints will be registered in the platform and assigned by the Coordinator (Management Representative, MR) to the relevant factory PIC(s) for investigation and corrective action. The Head of Department (HOD) will review and validate the complaint findings, while the Factory Manager (FM) will review and approve the proposed response before communication to the customer. Once corrective actions have been implemented, the Coordinator will verify completion and formally close the complaint.

This proposal seeks agreement on the business requirements and process flow before system development begins.

- Project PIC and Stakeholders: Review and confirm the requirements and outstanding items listed in Section 11. Provide feedback and agreement prior to system development.
- IT Department: Evaluate platform options against the requirements in Section 8. Recommend the preferred solution, including estimated cost, implementation effort, and timeline.
- Management: Approve the project budget and appoint a project sponsor upon receipt of IT's recommendation.
- Factories: Nominate responsible personnel for the roles of PIC, HOD, and FM. Confirm the group-level Coordinator (MR) for complaint management.

2. Objectives

Currently, customer complaints are managed separately by each factory using Excel files, making group-wide monitoring, reporting, and tracking difficult. Duplicate data entry also increases administrative effort and the risk of inconsistencies.

The proposed Customer Complaint Management Platform aims to:

1. Provide a single platform for all five factories to register and manage customer complaints.
2. Standardize complaint handling using a common complaint form for all complaint categories.
3. Improve visibility of complaint status, ownership, and aging through real-time tracking.
4. Enable management to monitor complaints through a centralized dashboard and reports.
5. Eliminate duplicate data entry by maintaining complaint records, investigations, and closure details in one system.
6. Support FSSC and internal quality requirements through complete and traceable complaint records.

3. Scope and phasing

Phase	Scope	Timing
Phase 1	Centralized complaint management for all factories, including complaint registration, assignment, tracking, investigation, closure, notifications, dashboard, reporting, and migration of 6 months of historical records.	Current project
Phase 2	Provide complaint status visibility to traders through integration with the traders' dashboard, enabling them to monitor complaints related to their customers and contracts.	After Phase 1

Phase 1 has no integration with other business systems, apart from email. Complaint types, roles and the workflow are settings that the MR can change.

4. Proposed process

The table describes each step and Figure 1 shows the process. It applies to all five factories. If an action is not done within 3 days, the platform sends a reminder to the person responsible.

Step	Who	What happens
1	Lodger	Opens a new complaint and selects the factory. The platform records the lodger's full name, department and factory, and the date and time. A reference number is created, for example FA/2026/0001.
2	Lodger	Completes the complaint form (section 5.1). The form can be saved as a draft at any time, but it can be submitted to the Coordinator only when the mandatory fields are filled in. These are fields a to k and the customer's email. When the form is submitted, the platform emails the Coordinator.
3	Coordinator (MR)	Reviews the complaint and assigns the investigation by selecting the email addresses of one or more PICs of the factory concerned. For example, for a quality complaint at Factory A, the Coordinator selects the Factory A Lab PIC and the Lab manager. The platform records who received the complaint and the date it was acknowledged, and emails each PIC with the reference number, a PDF summary of the complaint and a link to the full form.
4	PIC	Reviews the complaint and enters the investigation findings in the platform: root cause analysis, correction and corrective action. Attachments can be uploaded. The PIC's details appear in the response section. If a sample was sent, the laboratory enters the test results in the laboratory section (section 5.3). When the findings are complete, the PIC submits them to the HOD.
4a	PIC	If the cause is an external party, such as a supplier or a transporter, the PIC clicks Issue SCAR on the investigation form. The platform generates the SCAR from a template, filled with the complaint details and the complaint reference number, and the PIC sends it to that party by email from the platform. The status becomes Pending SCAR from Supplier. When the SCAR is returned, the PIC uploads it in the platform and submits the response to the HOD, and the platform emails the HOD. The reply to the customer cannot be sent until the supplier's investigation is back.
5	HOD	Reviews the findings and sets the case as Valid or Invalid. A reason is given when the case is Invalid. If the HOD does not agree with the findings, the HOD returns the complaint to the PIC with a comment, the platform emails the PIC, and the PIC improves the response and submits it to the HOD again. Otherwise the HOD submits the response to the FM (step 6), whether the complaint is valid or invalid and whether the cause is internal or external. It does not go through the Coordinator. The platform emails the FM, with the Coordinator and the PIC copied.
6	FM	Reviews the response. Each factory has one FM, and the FM's email address is set in the platform as the default. The FM approves or rejects the response. A rejection needs a comment, and the platform emails the PIC, the HOD and the Coordinator. The PIC then amends the response, or asks the supplier to improve the SCAR, and submits it to the HOD again. This repeats until the FM approves.
7	PIC	When the FM approves, the platform emails the PIC, the HOD and the Coordinator. The PIC drafts the reply email in the platform and sends it to the customer. The platform keeps a copy of the sent email and changes the status to Customer Response Sent. When the reply is sent, the HOD, FM and Coordinator are notified.
8	Coordinator (MR)	Reviews the effectiveness of the corrective action, which FSSC requires, and closes the case. The platform records the first and second verified dates and the date the case is closed.

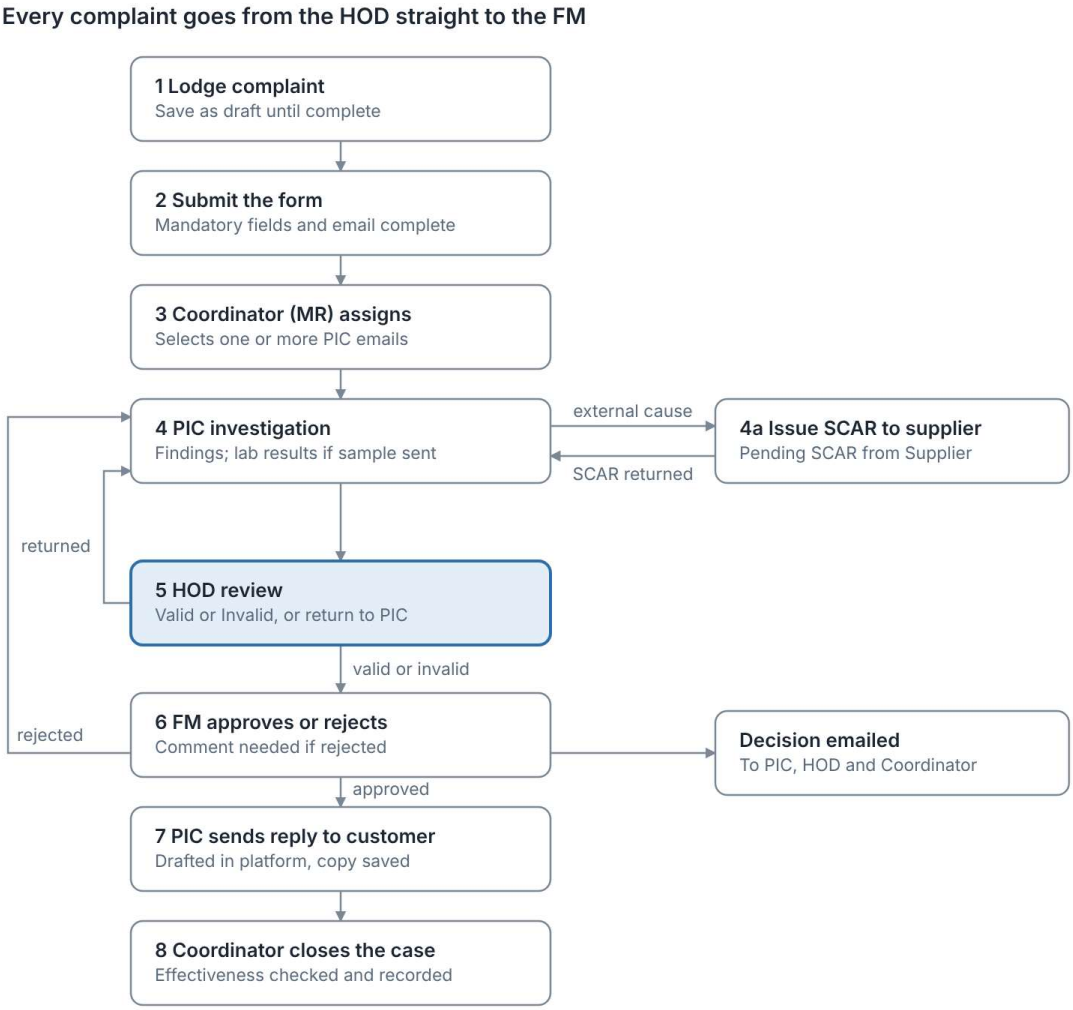


Figure 1. Complaint process

5. Requirements

5.1 Complaint form

The system fills in the lodger details and the date and time. The lodger completes the rest. Fields a to k and the customer's email are mandatory. The form can be saved as a draft with fields missing, but it can be submitted to the Coordinator only when every mandatory field is filled in.

Ref.	Field	Details	Mandatory
Auto	Lodger	Full name, department and factory of the person lodging the complaint, taken from the user profile.	Auto
Auto	Date and time	System date and time when the complaint is lodged.	Auto
Auto	Factory	Drop-down list: Factory A to Factory E.	Yes
Auto	Complaint ref. no.	Factory code, year and running number, for example FA/2026/0001, FB/2026/0001, FA/2026/0002. The running number is kept for each factory.	Auto
a	Buyer / party involved	Text.	Yes
b	Contract number	Text.	Yes

Ref.	Field	Details	Mandatory
c	Product name	Text.	Yes
d	Delivery date	Date.	Yes
e	Packing type	Drop-down list: Bulk or Pack. If Pack is selected, a field opens for the pack size, for example drum, flexibag or carton.	Yes
f	Affected quantity	Number, with a drop-down list for the unit (Metric Ton, Kg).	Yes
g	Transport type, vessel, vehicle and container	Drop-down list: Shipment - Bulk, Shipment - Container, Local Delivery - Bulk, Local Delivery - Container. The fields that open depend on the choice. Shipment - Bulk: vessel name. Shipment - Container: vessel name and container number. Local Delivery - Bulk: vehicle number. Local Delivery - Container: vehicle number and container number.	Yes
h	Loading port and port of discharge / final destination	Two text fields. The loading port is added to the original form.	Yes
i	Description of complaint	Large text box with enough space for details, placed below the complaint type.	Yes
j	Complaint type	Drop-down lists for type and sub-type (section 5.2). If Others is selected, a field opens for short details.	Yes
k	Sample sent to factory	Drop-down list: Yes or No.	Yes
l	DO / document reference	Text, if available.	No
m	Supporting documents and pictures	File upload, if available.	No
n	Contact person	Name of the contact person at the buyer or party involved, as on the current report.	No
o	Email, telephone and fax	Contact details of that person. The email address is mandatory, because the reply to the customer is sent by email. Telephone and fax are optional.	Email: Yes
p	Complaint method	Drop-down list of how the complaint was received. The choices are to be confirmed (see section 11).	No

5.2 Complaint types

Type	Sub-types
Product Quality	Quality - Off Spec; Quality - Foreign Matter; Quality - Others
Packaging	Packaging - Dented; Packaging - Leaking; Packaging - Labeling; Packaging - Damage Pallet; Packaging - Others
Logistic	Logistic - Wrong Delivery; Logistic - Shortage; Logistic - Transport Damage; Logistic - Others
Documentation	Documentation - Discrepancies; Documentation - Missing; Documentation - Late/Delay; Documentation - Others
Others	Short details entered by the lodger

The MR can add more complaint types and sub-types when required.

5.3 Sections completed during handling

The current report has a laboratory section and an IMS section. The platform keeps both in the same complaint record and fills them in as the complaint moves on.

Coordinator section (called the IMS section in the current report):

Field	Details
Received by	Name of the Coordinator, filled in by the system when the complaint is assigned.
Acknowledgement date	Date and time the Coordinator assigned the complaint, filled in by the system.
Assigned PIC(s)	One or more PIC email addresses chosen by the Coordinator from the list for the factory, for example the Lab PIC and the Lab manager. The platform emails each of them.
Remarks	Text.
Attachments	File upload.

Laboratory section. It opens when the answer to Sample sent to factory is Yes, and is filled in by the laboratory staff, who are among the PICs assigned by the Coordinator:

Field	Details
Tested by	Name of the laboratory staff, taken from the user profile.
Lab acknowledgement date	Date the laboratory received the sample.
Test results	A grid with two columns, From buyer's sample and From retained sample, and one row for each test: FFA, M&I, PV, IV, Colour, and Appearance and odour. The MR can change the list of tests.
Lab attachment	File upload, for example the test report.
Remarks	Text.
Date reply to customer / trader	Filled in by the system on the day the reply email is sent.

5.4 Other rules

Area	Requirement
Reply to customer	The email is built from a template and takes the investigation findings, root cause, corrective and preventive action, approval records and closure comments. Supporting documents can be attached. When it is sent, the platform saves a copy in the complaint record and sets the status to Customer Response Sent. If a SCAR is pending, the reply is held until the SCAR is returned and the FM has approved.
Notification	When the FM approves or rejects, the platform emails the PIC, the HOD and the Coordinator with the decision and any comment.
Reminders	A reminder is sent when an action has not been done within 3 days. The Coordinator can set the number of days for each complaint type.
Past complaints	Complaints from the past 6 months can be uploaded into the platform.
Deleting	A complaint is never removed. When one is deleted, it is marked Deleted with a reason and stays in the log. Who may delete is to be confirmed (see section 11).
Access	Access depends on the user's role and factory. The Coordinator and top management can see all factories.

Area	Requirement
Records	The platform keeps a log of who changed what and when. Each complaint and its documents can be retrieved for FSSC and ISO audits and exported as a PDF in the layout of the current Customer Complaint Report.

5.5 Complaint log

The platform builds the complaint log from the complaint records, so nothing is typed twice. It can be filtered by factory and period and exported to Excel with the columns of the current log, in the same order, except that the CAR number is not used. The table shows where each column comes from.

Column in the current log	Taken from
No., Customer complaint no.	Complaint ref. no., for example FA/2026/0001.
Complaint from	Buyer / party involved (a).
Complaint received by, Issue date	Lodger and the date and time the complaint was lodged.
Product, Delivery date	Product name (c) and delivery date (d).
Lab acknowledgement date	Laboratory section.
Date reply to buyer / trader	Date the reply email is sent to the customer.
IMS acknowledgement date, IMS remarks	Coordinator section.
Type of problem	Complaint type and sub-type (j).
Types of valid complaint	Complaint type, for complaints the HOD has set as Valid.
CAR no.	Not used. The complaint reference number is used instead, including on the SCAR.
Correction, Corrective action	The PIC’s findings.
First verified date, Second verified date, Date case closed	Closing by the Coordinator (step 8).
Remarks	Remarks.
Deleted, Reason delete	Set when a complaint is deleted, with the reason.

The summary under the current log is produced by the platform too: the total number of complaints, the numbers valid, invalid, under investigation and deleted, valid complaints in progress and closed, and the cases for each type of valid complaint (Figure 11).

6. Dashboard and reporting

The dashboard (Figure 10) shows how many complaints there are and of what type, their status, and where each open complaint is waiting.

Item	Requirement
Filter: factory	One or more factories, so that management can view the whole group or a single factory.
Filter: period	Complaint date from and to.
Complaints by type	Number of complaints for each complaint type.
Status	Under investigation, Valid, Invalid and Deleted, with the reason shown for invalid and deleted complaints. A valid complaint is In progress until the Coordinator closes the case, and then Closed. Pending SCAR from Supplier and Customer Response Sent are shown as stages.
Valid complaints by type	Number of cases for each type of valid complaint, with a total.
Open complaint aging	Number of days each open complaint has been open.
Where each complaint is	The current step and the person responsible for every open complaint, for example waiting for the PIC, a supplier's SCAR, the HOD, the Coordinator or the FM.
Summary	Total number of complaints, and how many are valid, invalid, under investigation and deleted.
List of complaints	The complaint log (section 5.5). Each line opens the complaint.
Traders' view (Phase 2)	The same information for a trader's own contracts.

7. Screens for each step

These examples show what the user sees at each step of the process. They are for discussion, not a final design, and all names and figures are made up.

Steps 1 and 2: Lodge and submit the complaint (lodger)

The lodger fills in the form. It can be saved as a draft at any time, and it can be submitted to the Coordinator only when fields a to k and the customer's email are filled in.

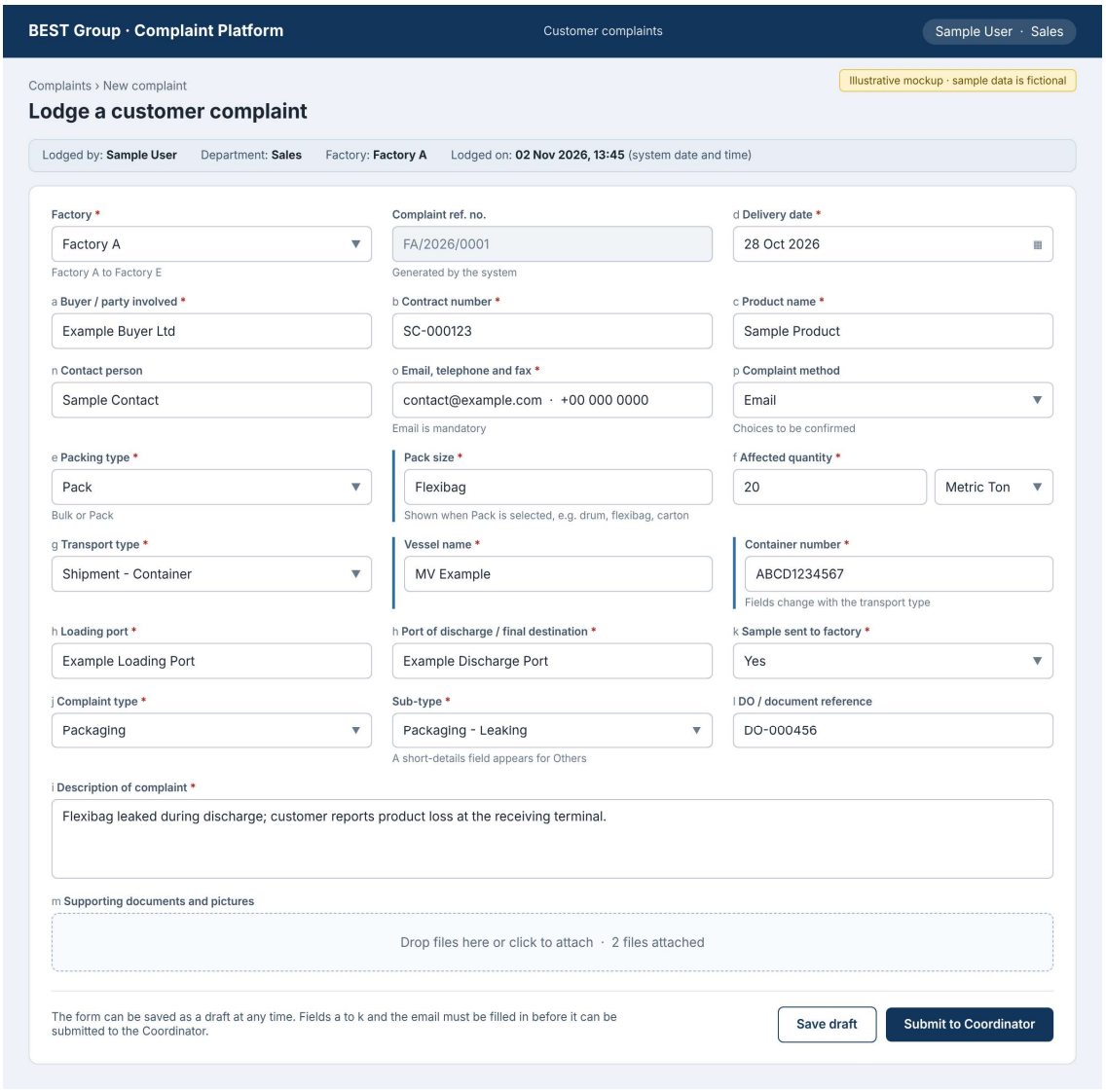


Figure 2. Lodge and submit the complaint

Step 3: Coordinator assigns the PICs

The Coordinator selects one or more PIC emails of the factory, adds remarks and sends. The platform emails each PIC the reference number, a PDF summary and a link.

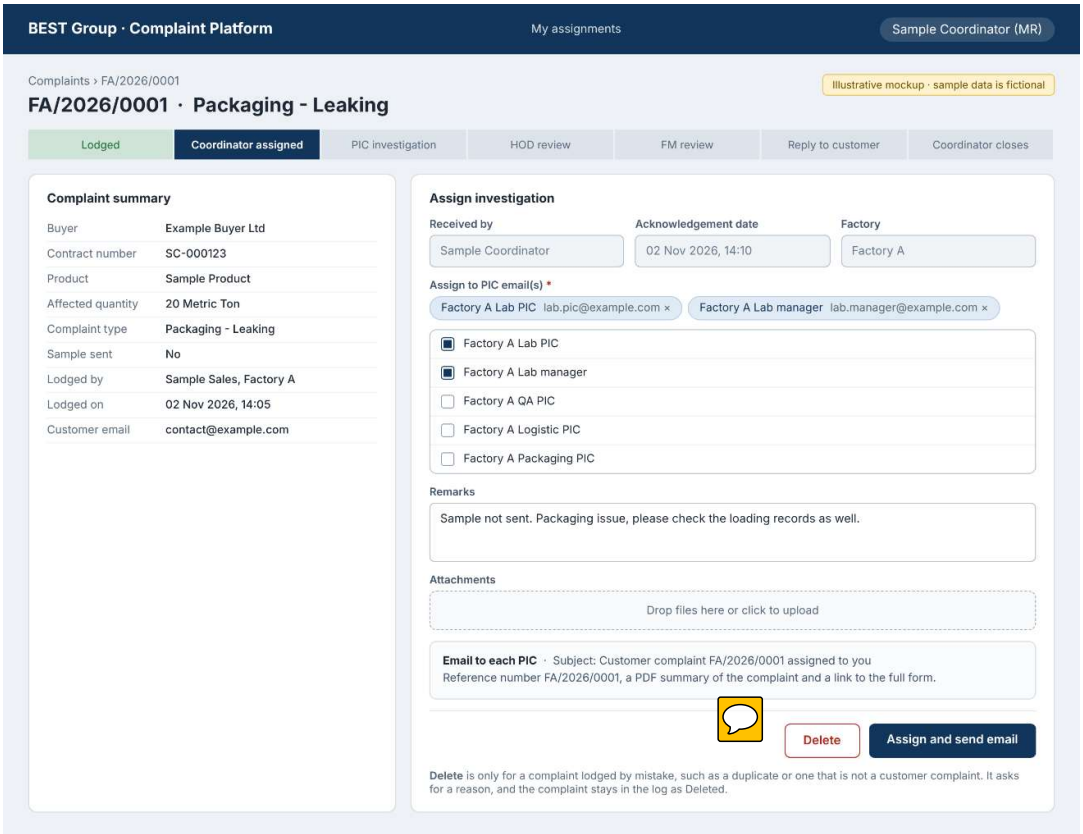


Figure 3. Coordinator assigns the PICs

Step 4: PIC investigation

The PIC enters the root cause, correction and corrective action, and attaches files. If a sample was sent, the laboratory section opens for the test results.

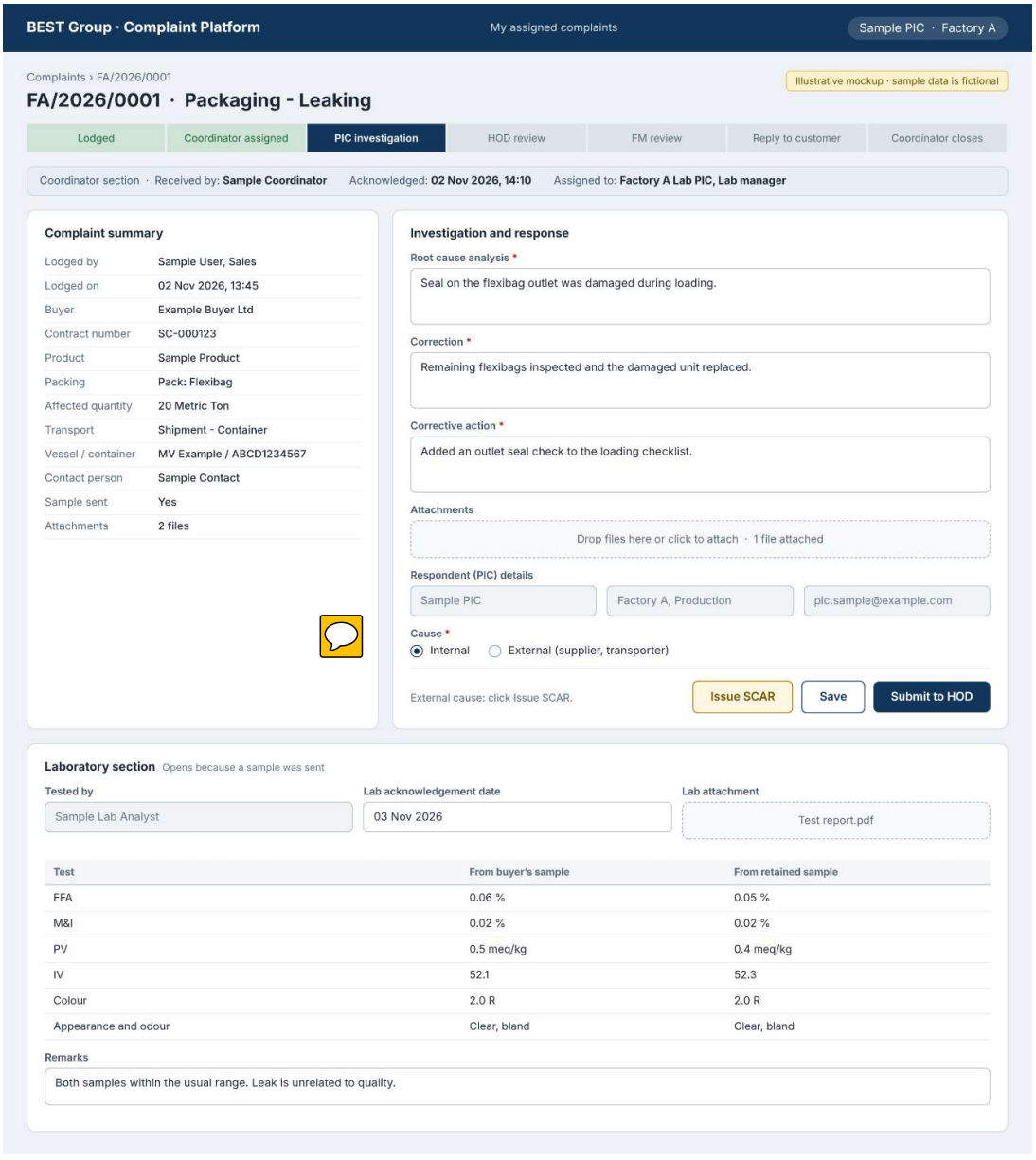


Figure 4. PIC investigation, with laboratory section

Step 4a: SCAR to an external party

When the cause is external, the PIC issues a SCAR under the complaint reference number. The status becomes Pending SCAR from Supplier, and Submit to HOD stays locked until the returned SCAR is uploaded.

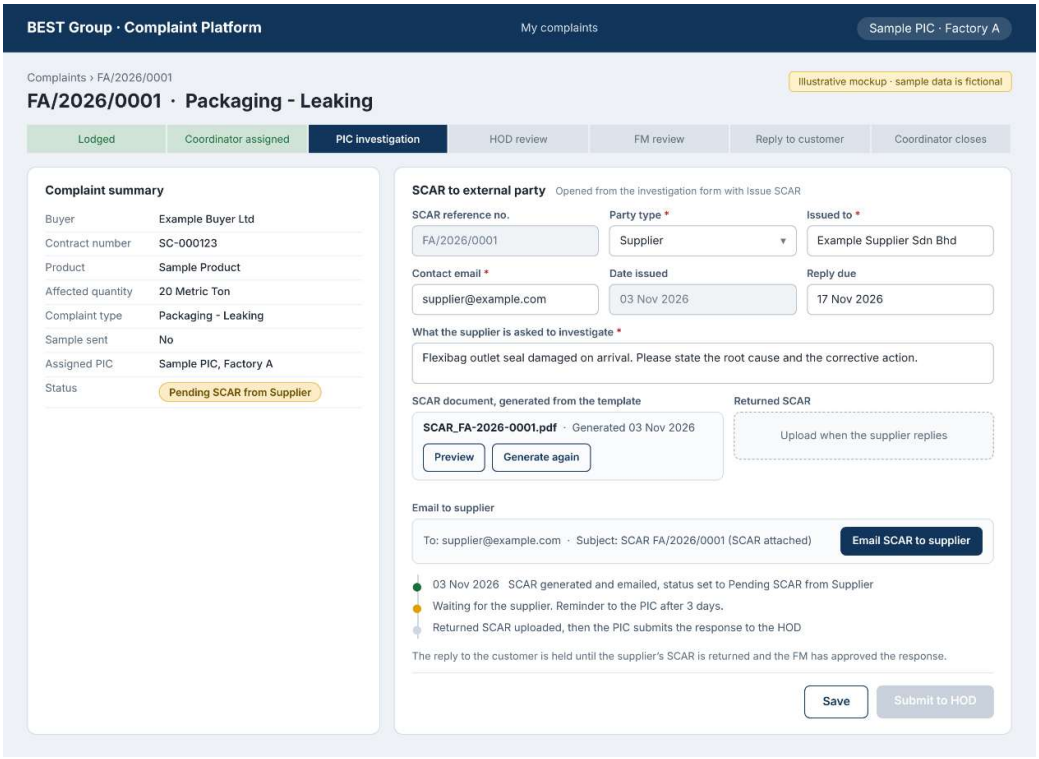


Figure 5. SCAR to a supplier or transporter

Step 5: HOD review

The HOD reads the PIC's findings, sets the complaint as Valid or Invalid, states the cause, and gives a reason if it is Invalid. The response then goes straight to the FM.

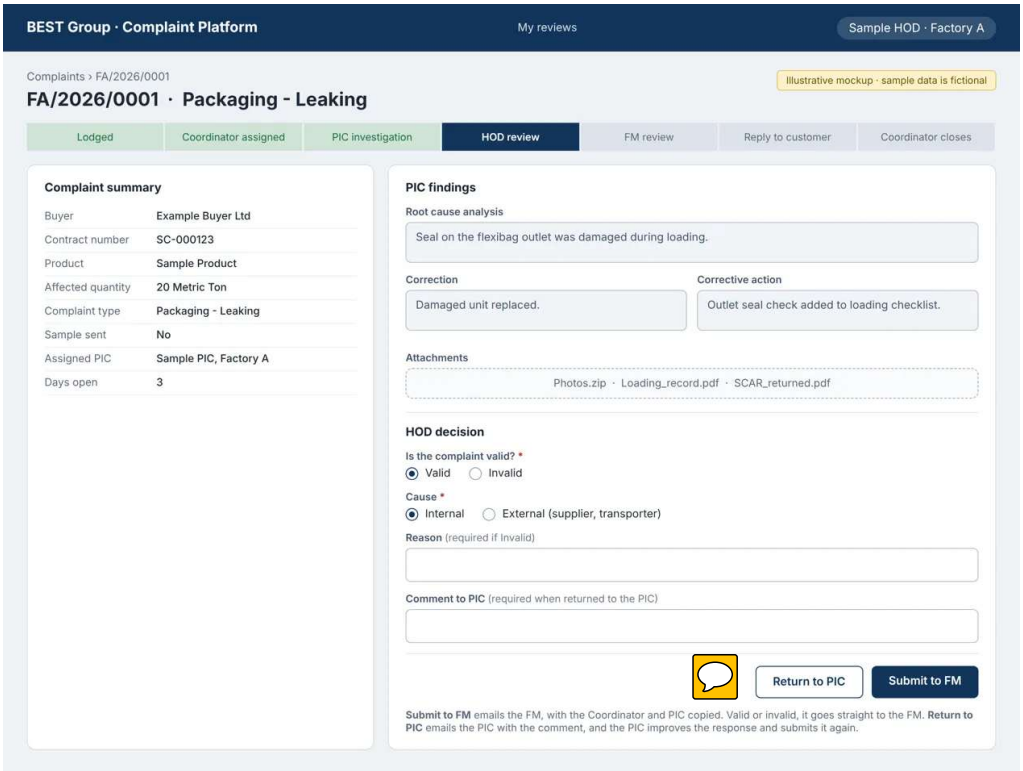


Figure 6. HOD review

Step 6: FM approves or rejects

The FM reads the response and approves or rejects it. A rejection needs a comment, and the PIC, HOD and Coordinator are emailed. The PIC then amends and resubmits to the HOD.

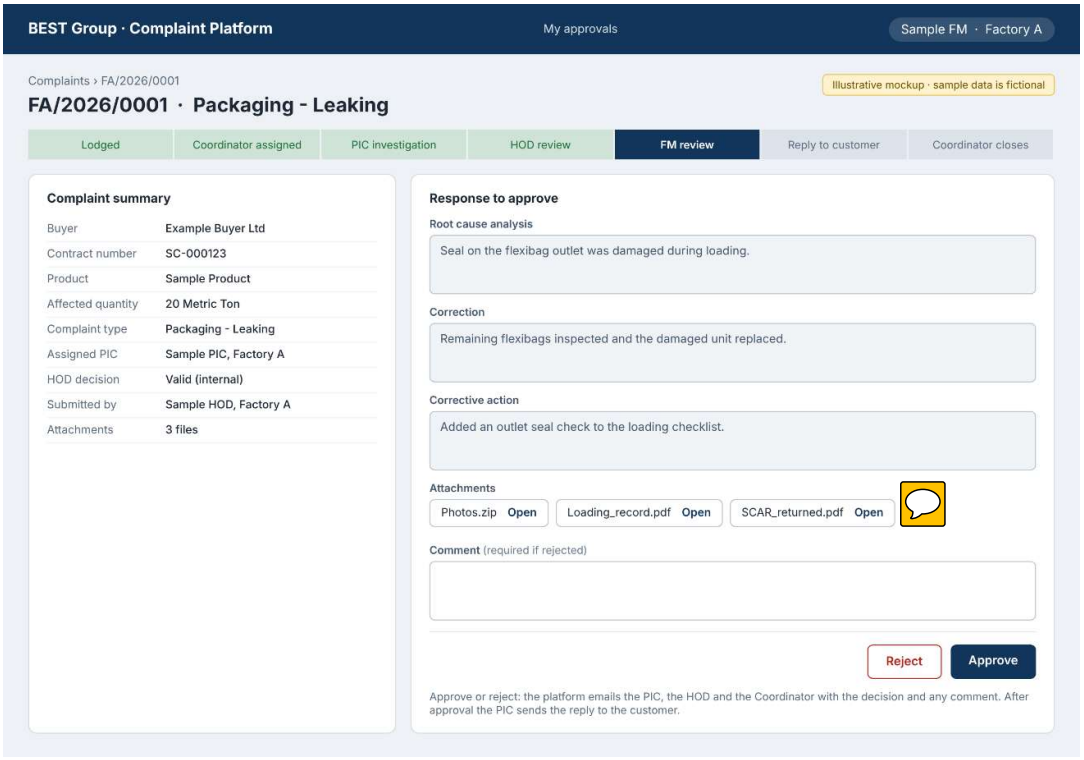


Figure 7. FM approval

Step 7: PIC replies to the customer

After approval, the PIC checks the email built from the template, edits it if needed and sends it. The platform saves a copy and sets the status to Customer Response Sent.

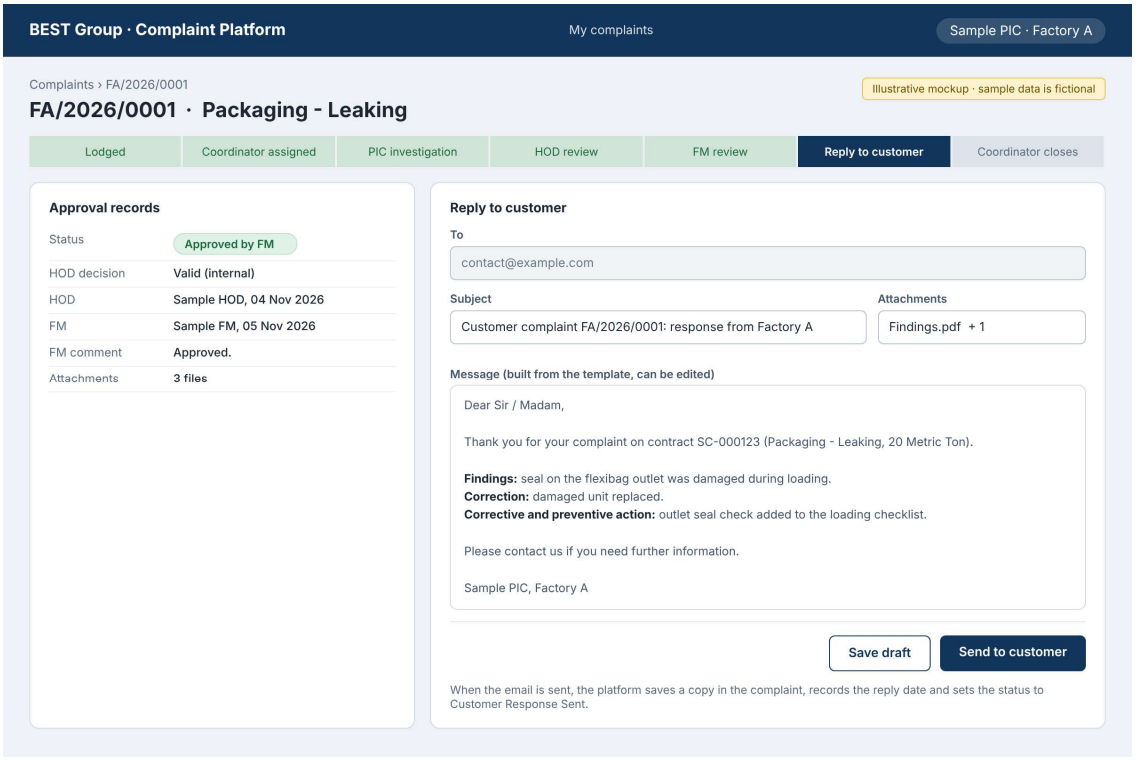


Figure 8. Reply to the customer

Step 8: Coordinator checks effectiveness and closes

The Coordinator records the first and second verified dates and the results, then closes the case. If the action is not effective, the case goes back to the PIC.

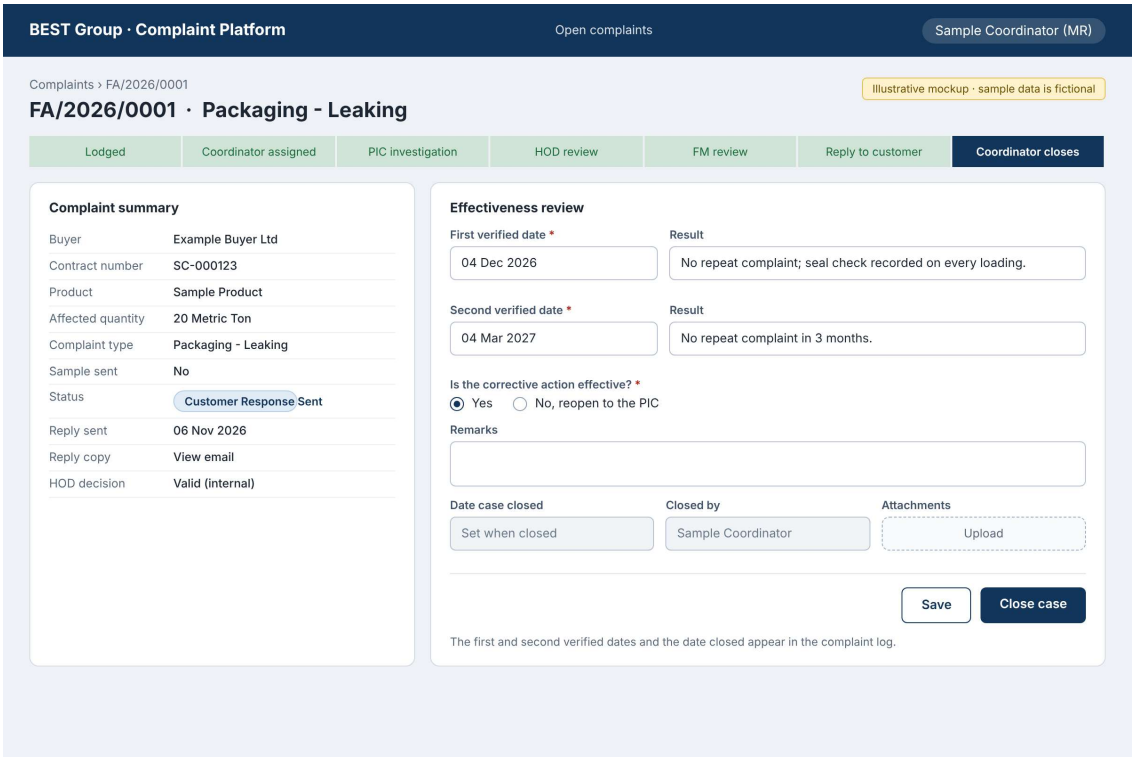


Figure 9. Effectiveness review and closing

Dashboard and complaint log

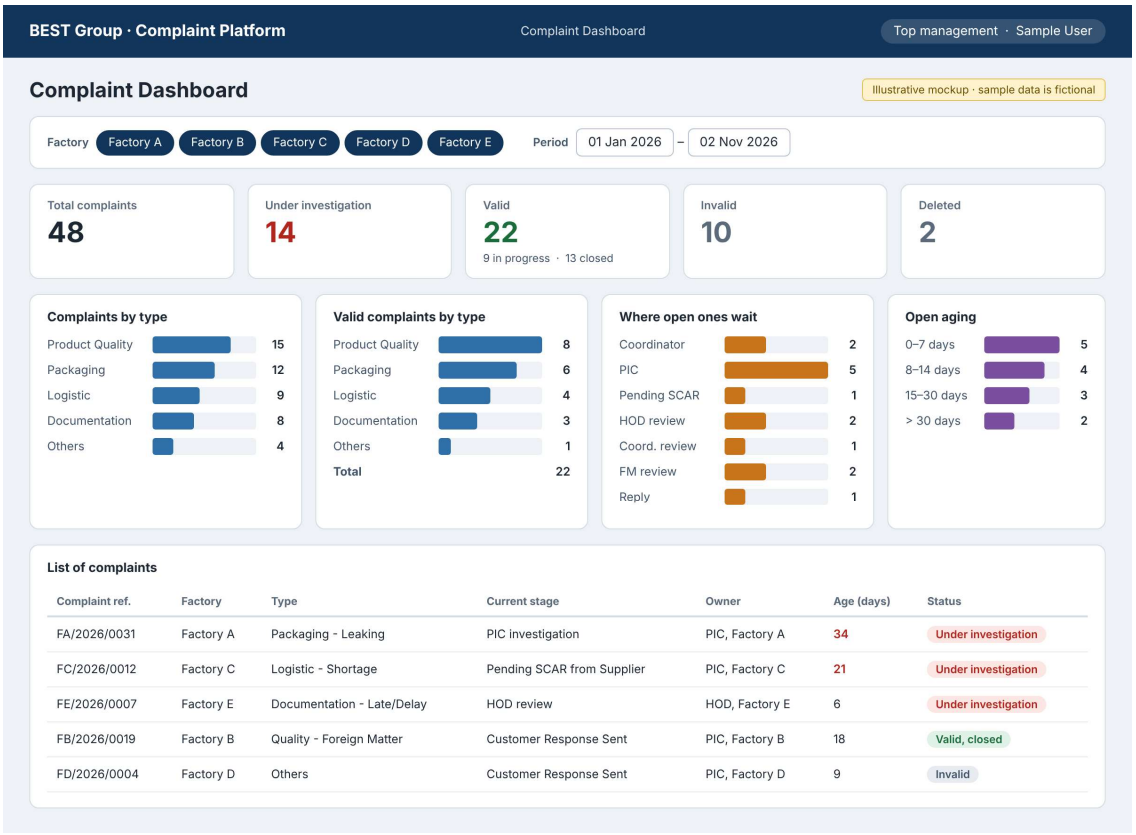


Figure 10. Complaint dashboard

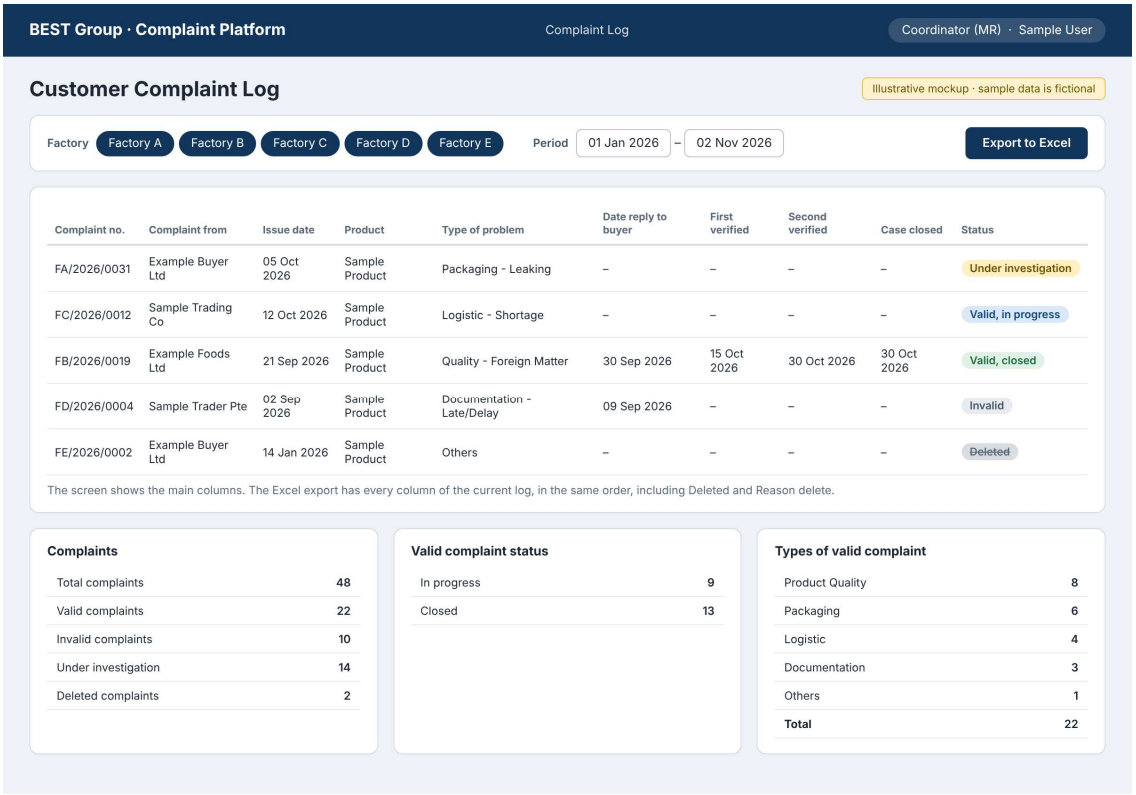


Figure 11. Complaint log

8. Platform and IT requirements

The factories have no platform for this today. IT will compare options against the requirements below and recommend one.

Requirement	Priority
Forms with fields that open depending on earlier choices, draft saving, and a check of mandatory fields before submission	Must have
Workflow with routing by role and factory, assignment of one or more PICs from a list kept for each factory, and approve or reject with a required comment and a repeat cycle	Must have
Status Pending SCAR from Supplier, upload of the returned SCAR, and the reply held until it is back	Must have
Emails sent from the platform to several people, with a PDF summary and a link, and reply emails built from a template	Must have
Reminders after a set number of days	Must have
File attachment, and upload of past complaints	Must have
Dashboard with filters, status, aging and a list of complaints	Must have
Complaint log built from the records, exported to Excel in the columns of the current log; complaint exported to PDF in the layout of the current report	Must have
Log of changes, and sections that open for a role or a choice, such as the laboratory section	Must have
User sign-in with role and factory, and drop-down lists the MR can maintain without IT	Must have
Data export or interface for the traders' dashboard	Needed for Phase 2

Options IT will consider:

- A low-code workflow platform: quick to build and change, but needs a licence and IT to build and support it.
- Ready-made quality management software with complaint and corrective action functions: some of the process may be built in, but it must be checked against this proposal, and it carries a licence cost.
- A custom-built application: matches the process exactly, but takes the longest to build and IT has to maintain it.

Extending each factory's current method is not recommended, because it keeps the factories on separate systems. IT will provide the recommended platform with the reasons, licence and build cost, yearly support cost, people needed and timeline. The budget can only be set after that, and we suggest Group management approves it on the recommendation of IT and the MR.

9. Implementation plan

Stage	Activity	Who	Duration
Agree requirements	The project PIC and all parties review this proposal and agree the requirements and open points. Development starts after this.	Project PIC, all parties, IT	To be set by the project PIC
Platform selection	IT recommends the platform. Management approves the budget and licence.	IT, management	2 to 4 weeks

Stage	Activity	Who	Duration
Preparation	Confirm the form, complaint types, laboratory tests, roles, the PICs, HOD, FM and laboratory staff of each factory, FM emails and reminder days.	MR, IT business analyst, factories	2 weeks
Build	Form, workflow, emails, reminders, dashboard, complaint log and report layouts, and upload of past complaints.	IT developers, business analyst	6 to 8 weeks
Pilot	One or two factories use the platform for live complaints. Issues are fixed.	Pilot factories, IT	2 to 4 weeks
Rollout	Remaining factories, training, and upload of the past 6 months of complaints.	MR, IT, factories	4 weeks

Phase 1 would take about 4 to 5 months from the date the requirements are agreed and the budget is approved. These are first estimates, to be confirmed by IT once the platform is chosen. IT needs a business analyst, one or two developers, a tester during the pilot, and support for user sign-in and the mail service the platform uses. The MR is the process owner, and the PICs, HOD and FM of each factory take part in preparation and testing.

10. Risks

Risk	Action
The parties may not agree on the requirements.	The requirements are reviewed with the project PIC before any development, and the open points in section 11 are settled first.
No platform exists today, so selection and budget approval could delay the start.	IT gives its recommendation early, and the budget request is prepared at the same time.
Factories work differently today and may not accept one common process.	The MR owns the standard form and complaint types. One or two factories pilot first.
The FM or HOD does not act in time, or is away.	A reminder is sent after 3 days. A deputy should be agreed for absences (see section 11).
A supplier is slow to return the SCAR, which holds the reply to the customer.	The status Pending SCAR from Supplier shows on the dashboard, and the reminder goes to the PIC.
Emails from the platform may be blocked or treated as spam by customers' mail systems.	IT sets up a company mailbox or mail service for the platform and tests it before the pilot.

11. Open points

#	Point	Assumed for now
1	Who approves when the FM or HOD is away?	To be decided. A deputy for each factory could be set in the platform.
2	How many past complaints will be uploaded, and in what format?	Complaints from the past 6 months, from a spreadsheet using one template.
3	What is the budget?	To be set after IT's recommendation.
4	The current report has the fields Business Type and Type of Management. What do they mean, and what are their choices?	Left out of the form until they are explained.
5	Is the IMS section of the current report done by the Coordinator (MR)?	Yes.

#	Point	Assumed for now
6	What are the choices for Complaint method? Are FFA, M&I, PV, IV, colour, and appearance and odour the tests for every product and factory?	Choices to be given by the MR. The six tests are used for now, and the MR can change the list.
7	Who may mark a complaint as Deleted?	The Coordinator only, with a reason.
8	Who keeps the list of PIC email addresses for each factory, for example the Lab PIC and the Lab manager?	The Coordinator, with each factory naming its PICs.
9	The PIC issues a SCAR before the HOD decides whether the complaint is valid, so a SCAR may exist for a complaint later set as Invalid. After the SCAR is returned, does the HOD still confirm valid or invalid?	Yes. The HOD decides after the SCAR is received, and the SCAR stays in the record.
10	Are the first and second verified dates still needed now that CAR numbers are not used?	Yes. The Coordinator records them when closing the case.

Appendix A. Terms used

Term	Meaning
Lodger	The person who records the complaint in the platform. Any internal stakeholder can lodge, for example a trader, marketeer, sales person, factory staff, or the management, finance team or shared service team.
Coordinator / MR	Management Representative. Acts as the group Complaint Coordinator, assigns each complaint to the PICs, and closes the case.
PIC	Person in charge at the factory who investigates the complaint and replies to the customer. A complaint can have more than one PIC, for example the Lab PIC and the Lab manager.
HOD	Head of Department. Decides whether a complaint is valid or invalid.
FM	Factory Manager (Factory Head). One FM for each factory.
SCAR	Supplier Corrective Action Report, issued by the PIC to an external party such as a supplier or a transporter, using the complaint reference number.
IMS	The department named in the current report that acknowledges the complaint and adds remarks. This proposal assumes the Coordinator (MR) takes this role.
FFA, M&I, PV, IV	Laboratory tests on the current report: free fatty acid, moisture and impurities, peroxide value and iodine value.
FSSC	Food Safety System Certification (FSSC 22000).